Workshop-in-a-Box: 90-Minute Priority-Setting Session

Nov 10, 2026 · @Ekci

About this kit

In 90 minutes, a team moves from a long list of good ideas to three agreed priorities, a short "not now" list, and an owner for each next step. The session is built for foundation, NGO and programme teams who have more worthy options than budget, and who need a decision they can defend to a board.

Who it is for: 6 to 16 participants (programme staff, leadership, trustees), one facilitator, one note-taker if possible. Works in person or online.

What participants leave with:

1. A shared picture of the evidence behind the decision
2. Explicit, agreed criteria for what "priority" means for this organisation
3. A scored and mapped set of options, with disagreements made visible
4. Three priorities, a "not now" list and named owners, recorded on one page

What is in the box:

Component	Use
This facilitator guide	Agenda, timed run-sheet, scripts, exercise steps, watch-outs
Slide deck (15 slides)	Projected throughout; one slide per step, instructions on screen
Evidence card template	Pre-work: 4 to 6 data points that frame the choice
Scoring sheet	Exercise 3: each person scores options against the criteria
Decision record	The one-page output, completed live in the last 15 minutes

The design principle: evidence before opinion, criteria before options are judged, and individual thinking before group discussion. That order keeps the loudest voice or the longest-standing programme from deciding by default.

Before the session

Most of the session's quality is set in the week before it. Agree the decision question with the sponsor, prepare the evidence cards, and pre-load the candidate options so the room spends its time judging, not listing.

One to two weeks before (with the sponsor, 30 to 45 minutes):

- [ ] Agree the decision question in one sentence, e.g. "Which three areas will we prioritise in our 2027–2029 grant-making?"
- [ ] Confirm what is in scope (budget envelope, time horizon, geography) and what is already fixed
- [ ] Confirm who decides: the room recommends, or the room decides
- [ ] Draft 6 to 12 candidate options from strategy papers, staff input and past grants
- [ ] Propose 3 to 4 criteria (see Exercise 2) for the sponsor to sanity-check

Three to five days before:

- [ ] Build 4 to 6 evidence cards: one data point each, with source and a one-line "so what"
- [ ] Send participants a one-page pre-read: the question, the evidence cards, the draft option list
- [ ] Ask each participant to add up to two options they think are missing
- [ ] Print scoring sheets (one per person) and the decision record (A3 if possible)

Materials:

In person	Online
Projector and the slide deck	Video call with breakout rooms
Evidence cards printed A4, taped on walls	Evidence cards on a shared whiteboard (Miro, Mural)
Sticky notes in two colours, marker pens	Digital sticky notes, two colours
Round dot stickers, 3 per person	Dot-voting stamps on the whiteboard
Flipchart with the 2x2 matrix drawn large	2x2 matrix frame on the whiteboard
Printed scoring sheets	Shared scoring form or spreadsheet
Timer visible to the room	On-screen timer

Room setup: tables in small groups of 3 to 4 (cabaret style), evidence cards spaced around the walls, the 2x2 flipchart at the front next to the screen. Online: test breakout rooms and whiteboard permissions the day before, and send the board link with the calendar invite.

Agenda at a glance

Six segments, each ending in a visible output that feeds the next. Times are from the start of the session.

Time	Min	Segment	Method	Output	Slides
0:00–0:10	10	Open: why we are here	Framing + quick pulse check	Shared decision question	1–4
0:10–0:25	15	Exercise 1: What the evidence says	Silent gallery walk, three-colour reactions	Surprises and gaps named	5–6
0:25–0:40	15	Exercise 2: What "priority" means here	1-2-4-All on criteria	3 to 4 agreed criteria	7–8
0:40–1:05	25	Exercise 3: Score and map the options	Individual scoring, then the Need × Fit matrix	Options placed on the 2x2, splits visible	9–11
1:05–1:22	17	Exercise 4: Commit and let go	Dot vote, then Now / Next / Not now	Top 3, "not now" list, owners	12–13
1:22–1:30	8	Close	Decision read-back, one-word check-out	Signed-off decision record	14–15

Buffer: the agenda carries no spare time on paper. If you run over, take minutes from Exercise 1 (shorten the walk to 6 minutes) before touching Exercises 3 or 4, where the decision is made.

Facilitator run-sheet

Each segment below gives the purpose, a script you can read or adapt, the steps, and what to watch for. Words in quotation marks are suggested facilitator lines.

0:00–0:10 · Open: why we are here (slides 1–4)

Purpose: everyone knows the question, the output and the rules before any idea is discussed.

Script: "In 90 minutes we will have three priorities, a list of things we are consciously not doing yet, and a name next to each next step. We will not solve how to deliver them today. We will decide what matters most, and why."

1. Show the decision question (slide 2). Read it aloud and leave it on screen for 30 seconds.
2. Walk through the agenda and the output (slide 3).
3. Agree three working agreements (slide 4): evidence before opinion; challenge the idea, not the person; "not now" is not "never".
4. Pulse check: "On a scale of 1 to 5, how clear are we today on our priorities?" Hands up or a quick poll. Note the spread; you will ask again at the close.

Watch for: a senior person reframing the question at the start. Park it visibly: "Let's note that and test it against the evidence in ten minutes."

0:10–0:25 · Exercise 1: What the evidence says (slides 5–6)

Purpose: build a shared fact base so later debate is about the same reality.

Script: "Before we talk about options, let's look at what we know. Walk the room in silence. On each card, leave a sticky note: green if it confirms what you thought, yellow if it surprised you, pink if it raises a question."

1. Silent gallery walk, 8 minutes. Participants react to each of the 4 to 6 evidence cards.
2. Groups of 3 to 4 return to tables, 3 minutes: "What is the one card that should most shape our decision?"
3. Plenary harvest, 4 minutes: one sentence per table. Capture surprises and questions on a flipchart titled "What we now know / What we still don't".

Watch for: discussion of data quality taking over. Acknowledge it, log it under "What we still don't know", and move on. Silence matters here: protect it, and quiet personalities often contribute most at this stage.

0:25–0:40 · Exercise 2: What "priority" means here (slides 7–8)

Purpose: agree how options will be judged before anyone defends a favourite.

Script: "If we agree the yardstick first, we can disagree about the options honestly. What should make something a priority for us?"

Run it as **1-2-4-All**:

1. **1 (2 min):** alone, write the two criteria that matter most to you.
2. **2 (3 min):** in pairs, agree your top two.
3. **4 (4 min):** in fours, agree your top three.
4. **All (6 min):** each group shares; cluster on the flipchart and converge on 3 to 4 criteria.

Starter criteria to offer if the room stalls (slide 8):

- **Need:** scale and severity of the problem, and how neglected it is by other funders

- **Fit:** match to our mission, expertise, networks and added value
- **Feasibility:** cost, partner capacity, timeframe, risk
- **Evidence:** proof that the approach works, or a credible path to learning

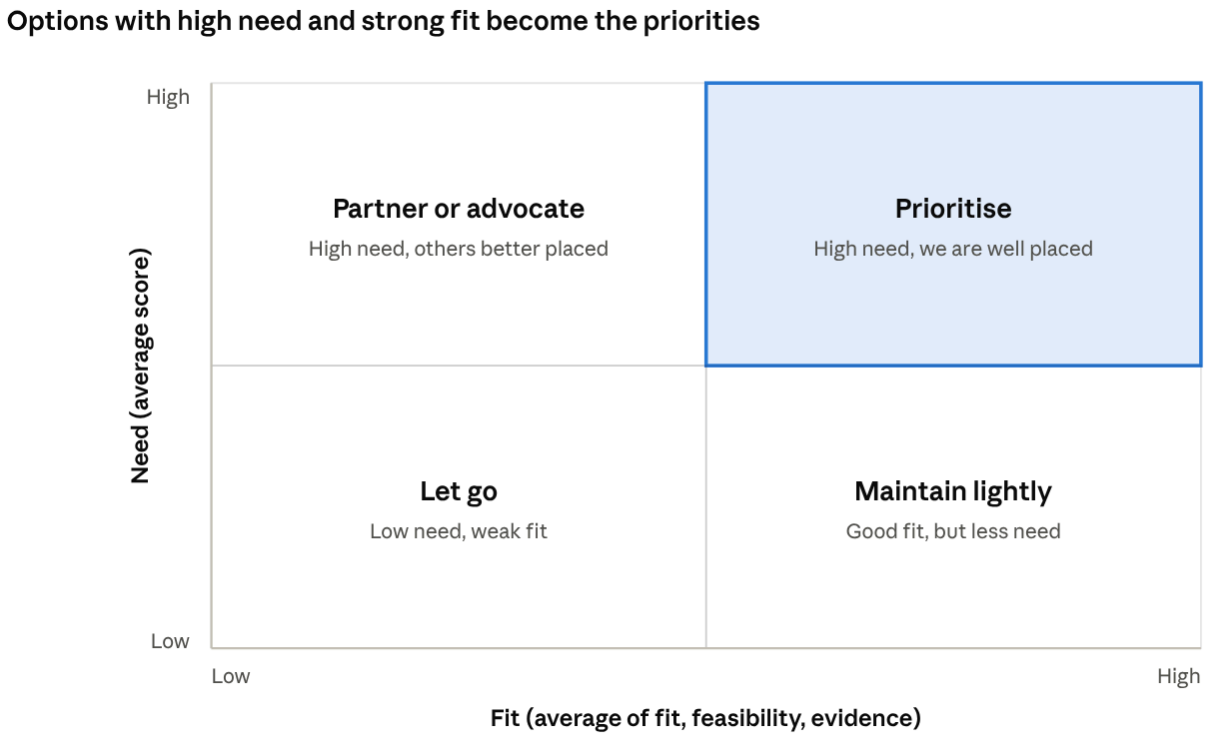
Watch for: criteria that are really options in disguise ("climate" is an option; "neglected by other funders" is a criterion). Close the segment by reading the final criteria back and getting a visible nod.

0:40–1:05 · Exercise 3: Score and map the options (slides 9–11)

Purpose: turn opinions into a visible, comparable picture, and surface where the room genuinely disagrees.

Script: "Score alone first. Your score is your honest view, not a negotiation. Then we will see where we agree, and where we really don't."

1. Show the option list (6 to 12 items, from the pre-read plus additions). Clarify, but do not debate, any item: 3 minutes.
2. **Individual scoring, 7 minutes:** each person scores every option 1 to 5 on each criterion using the scoring sheet.
3. **Collate, 5 minutes:** the note-taker averages the scores (a spreadsheet is fastest). Combine into two axes: **Need** on one, **Fit** (fit, feasibility and evidence averaged) on the other. Meanwhile, ask the room: "Which option did you find hardest to score, and why?"
4. **Map, 10 minutes:** place each option on the Need × Fit matrix (slide 10). Then show the spread (slide 11): highlight the 2 or 3 options with the widest disagreement and ask a high scorer and a low scorer to each explain their reasoning in 60 seconds.



Need × Fit matrix · draw it large on a flipchart

The quadrant names give the room a shared language: "Prioritise" options are candidates for Now; "Partner or advocate" options may matter but belong with another funder or in a co-funding conversation; "Let go" options are the honest start of the Not now list.

Watch for: the urge to re-score until everyone agrees. Disagreement is information. The question is not "who is right?" but "what would we need to know to settle this?" Log those questions.

1:05–1:22 · Exercise 4: Commit and let go (slides 12–13)

Purpose: make the choice and, just as important, name what will not be prioritised.

Script: "We can't do everything well. Each of you has three dots. Put them on the options that should be our priorities for the period ahead. You can put more than one dot on an option."

1. **Dot vote, 4 minutes**, with the matrix in view.
2. **Sort, 8 minutes:** move each option into **Now** (top 3), **Next** (revisit at the next planning point) or **Not now** (consciously deprioritised). Test the top 3 against the matrix: "Is anything in Now sitting in the low-need, low-fit corner? If so, why?"
3. **Owners, 5 minutes:** for each Now priority, one named owner and one next step with a date. Write them straight onto the decision record.

Watch for: "Not now" becoming empty because nobody wants to say no. Ask directly: "What are we agreeing to stop or pause, so the top three get real attention?" If the room cannot agree a top three, record the top five and the open question, and agree who decides and by when.

1:22–1:30 · Close (slides 14–15)

Purpose: confirm the decision, check confidence, and make the follow-up concrete.

1. Read the decision record aloud: the three priorities, the "not now" list, owners and dates.
2. Repeat the pulse check from the opening. Name the change.
3. One-word check-out: "One word for how you leave this session."
4. Confirm what happens next: who circulates the record, by when, and when the group reconvenes.

Watch for: new options raised in the last five minutes. Thank the person, add it to "Next", and protect the close.

Templates

Copy these into your own documents or print them. Each has a matching slide so participants see the same layout on screen.

Evidence card (one per data point, 4 to 6 in total)

Field	What to write	Example
Headline	The finding in one short sentence	"Half of our grants go to the region with a third of the need"
The number	One figure, large	52% vs 33%
Source	Dataset or report, year	Internal grants database 2023–2025; needs data from a public source
So what?	One line on why it matters for this decision	"Our footprint may not match where need is greatest"

Good cards mix internal data (where our money goes, what results we see) with external data (where need is, what other funders cover). Keep each card to one point; a card with three charts does not get read on a wall.

Scoring sheet (one per participant)

Score each option from 1 (low) to 5 (high) on each criterion. Leave blank if you genuinely cannot judge.

Option	Need	Fit	Feasibility	Evidence	Hardest to score? (✓)
Option A					
Option B					
Option C					
Option D					
Option E					
Option F					

For the matrix: the vertical axis is the average **Need** score; the horizontal axis is the average of **Fit**, **Feasibility** and **Evidence**. Replace the column names with the criteria your group agreed in Exercise 2.

Decision record (completed live, circulated within 48 hours)

Decision question: _____

Date and participants: _____

Priority	Why it ranks here (criteria + evidence)	Owner	Next step	By when
Now 1				
Now 2				
Now 3				

Next (revisit at next planning point)	Not now (consciously deprioritised)

Open questions to resolve: _____

Confidence before / after (pulse check, 1 to 5): _____ / _____

After the session, and going further

The decision record is the deliverable: circulate it within 48 hours, while the reasoning is fresh, and book the follow-up before people leave the room.

- [ ] Circulate the decision record and the photographed matrix within 48 hours
- [ ] Send the open questions to their owners with a date to answer
- [ ] Put the "Next" list on the agenda of the next planning or board meeting
- [ ] Re-run the pulse check after 3 months: are the three priorities still driving decisions?

When to bring in SA Analytical. This kit works well for a team that already has its evidence and a clear decision owner. Teams often go further with support when they need to:

- Build the evidence base itself: needs analysis, funding-gap and neglect data, or a review of the existing portfolio
- Facilitate with a neutral party, especially when trustees, staff and partners hold different views
- Turn the three priorities into a theory of change with measurable outcomes
- Extend the session into a full-day or multi-stakeholder strategy workshop

SA Analytical designs and facilitates data-backed strategy workshops for foundations, NGOs and international organisations. Contact: info@sa-analytical.com